

Marsupials

The earliest mammals reproduced by laying eggs, but by the Cretaceous Period mammals had evolved new ways of reproducing. The marsupials and their close relatives gave birth to tiny babies that developed outside the mother's body, often in a pouch. Today, most marsupials are found in Australia, but in the past they were very common in South America and Antarctica too.

Thylacosmilus

THIGH-lah-coe-SMILE-us



- **When** 10–2 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** S. America
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 5 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Meat

Thylacosmilus looked just like a saber-toothed cat, but it was a close relative of the marsupials. It was the size of a jaguar and built like a cat, but details of its skeleton show it was more like a giant opossum than a member of the cat family. Its huge canine teeth rested on odd-looking bony extensions of its chin, and unlike the teeth of cats they never stopped growing.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features of marsupials

- Give birth to tiny, immature babies
- Babies usually develop inside a pouch
- Four pairs of molar teeth
- Furry or hairy body
- Mothers produce milk for young

When

Marsupials first appeared in the Early Cretaceous (about 125 million years ago). Today, there are close to 300 marsupials, including kangaroos, wombats, and koalas.

